

August 12, 2026

Ambetter from Absolute Total Care  
Provider Appeals Department

**RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Isaura Larkin (MRN MUSC3566958), Claim MUSC-20260618-26B6-1**

|                          |                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Patient</b>           | Isaura Larkin (DOB 1950-01-12)                                                                                      |
| <b>MRN</b>               | MUSC3566958                                                                                                         |
| <b>Member ID / Group</b> | AMB642900279 / GRP-36295                                                                                            |
| <b>Claim number</b>      | MUSC-20260618-26B6-1                                                                                                |
| <b>Date of service</b>   | 2026-06-18                                                                                                          |
| <b>Procedure billed</b>  | CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity                                       |
| <b>Primary diagnosis</b> | J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified                                                              |
| <b>Denied amount</b>     | \$607.54                                                                                                            |
| <b>Denial code</b>       | CARC 50 / RARC N115 — These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer. |
| <b>Appeal deadline</b>   | 2026-11-03                                                                                                          |

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

**SUMMARY OF APPEAL**

MUSC Health is submitting this formal appeal on behalf of Isaura Larkin (MRN: MUSC3566958, Member ID: AMB642900279) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-20260618-26B6-1 for services rendered on June 18, 2026, at MUSC Health Rutledge Tower Ambulatory Care. Ambetter from Absolute Total Care denied the claim under CARC 50 ("These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer") with RARC N115, stating that "documentation submitted does not establish that the service was reasonable and necessary for the diagnosis reported." MUSC Health respectfully disagrees with this determination and requests full reversal and payment at the contracted allowed amount of \$313.01.

## CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Ms. Larkin is a 76-year-old established patient with a complex and longstanding medical history that directly informs the clinical necessity of the June 18, 2026 encounter. Her active conditions include chronic obstructive bronchitis with onset dating to 1981, chronic sinusitis with onset dating to 1961, osteoarthritis of the knee, hyperlipidemia managed with simvastatin, and prediabetes. She is a former tobacco smoker with a documented history of pulmonary rehabilitation and serial spirometry performed across multiple prior years. The primary diagnosis billed for the June 18 encounter was J06.9, acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified, with a secondary diagnosis of R69. In a patient carrying active chronic obstructive bronchitis and chronic sinusitis, an acute upper respiratory infection represents a clinically significant event requiring physician evaluation to assess for exacerbation, superimposed bacterial infection, and medication management — particularly given her age and comorbidity burden.

## BASIS FOR APPEAL

The service billed was CPT 99214, an established patient office visit of moderate complexity, rendered by Daniel R. Okafor, MD (NPI 1558493021) at place of service 22. This level of service is consistent with the clinical complexity presented. Ms. Larkin's active chronic obstructive bronchitis places her at elevated risk whenever an acute upper respiratory illness occurs, as such infections are a well-recognized precipitant of pulmonary exacerbation in patients with obstructive airway disease. Evaluation by a physician to assess respiratory status, review current medications, and determine whether escalation of treatment is warranted is both clinically appropriate and consistent with generally accepted standards of care for this patient population.

The payer's reliance on a Local Coverage Determination as the basis for denial, as indicated by RARC N115, is not applicable here. LCD policies are instruments of the Medicare program administered by Medicare Administrative Contractors and do not govern commercial Marketplace plan coverage determinations. Ambetter from Absolute Total Care is an ACA Marketplace product, and the application of an LCD framework to deny a Marketplace claim is procedurally inappropriate. Medical necessity for this claim should be evaluated under the plan's own coverage criteria and accepted clinical standards, not under a Medicare LCD.

Furthermore, the denial characterization that the service was not reasonable and necessary is inconsistent with the documented clinical picture. An acute upper respiratory infection in a 76-year-old patient with active chronic obstructive bronchitis, chronic sinusitis, prediabetes, and hyperlipidemia, managed by an established treating physician, clearly warrants a moderate-complexity evaluation and management visit. The billed level of service reflects the medical decision-making required to safely manage this patient's acute presentation in the context of her chronic conditions.

## REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Ambetter from Absolute Total Care conduct a full clinical review of this appeal, reverse the medical necessity denial for Claim MUSC-20260618-26B6-1, and issue payment at the contracted allowed amount of \$313.01 for CPT 99214 rendered on June 18, 2026. Should additional clinical documentation be required to support this review, MUSC Health will provide it promptly upon request through the secure provider portal prior to the appeal deadline of November 3, 2026.

Respectfully submitted,

**Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC**

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**Enclosures**

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record